

WEAK THESIS STATEMENTS: RECOGNIZING AND FIXING THEM

A strong thesis makes a claim that (1) requires analysis to support and evolve it and (2) offers some point about the significance of your evidence that would not have been immediately obvious to your readers. By contrast, a weak thesis either makes no claim or makes a claim that does not need proving.

Five kind of weak thesis statements—ones that

1. make no claim (“This paper will examine the pros and cons of...”);
2. are obviously true or are a statement of fact (“Exercise is good for you”);
3. restate conventional wisdom (“Love conquers all”);
4. offer personal conviction as the basis for the claim (“Shopping malls are wonderful places”);and
5. make an overly broad claim (“Individualism is good”).

WEAK THESIS TYPE 1: THE THESIS MAKES NO CLAIM. PROBLEM EXAMPLES...

I’m going to write about Darwin’s concerns with evolution in *The Origin of Species*.

This paper will address the characteristics of a good corporate manager.

These examples name a subject and link it to the intention to write about it, but they don’t make any claim about that subject. There is, in short, nothing at stake, no issue to be resolved.

Solution: Raise specific issues for the essay to explore. Possible examples:

Darwin’s concern with survival of the fittest in *The Origin of Species* leads him to neglect a potentially conflicting aspect of his theory of evolution—survival as a matter of interdependence.

The very trait that makes for an effective corporate manager—the drive to succeed—can also make the leader domineering and therefore ineffective.

WEAK THESIS TYPE 2: THE THESIS IS OBVIOUSLY TRUE OR IS A STATEMENT OF FACT.

PROBLEM EXAMPLES...

The jeans industry targets its advertisements to appeal to young adults.

If few people would disagree with the claim that a thesis makes, there is no point in writing an analytical paper on it.

Solution: *Find some avenue of INQUIRY—a question about the facts or an issue raised by them. Make an assertion with which it would be possible for readers to disagree.*

By inventing new terms, such as “loose fit” and “relaxed fit”, the jean industry has attempted to normalize its product for an older and fatter generation.

WEAK THESIS TYPE 3: THE THESIS RESTATES CONVENTIONAL WISDOM. PROBLEM EXAMPLES...

An important part of one’s college education is learning to better understand others’ points of view.

From cartoons in the morning to adventure shows at night, there is too much violence on television.

These examples say nothing worth proving because they are clichés. (Conventional wisdom is a polite term for clichés.) Most clichés were fresh ideas once, but over time they have become trite, prefabricated forms of non-thinking. There is some truth in the problem examples above, but none of them complicates its position.

Solution: *Seek to complicate—see more than one point of view on—your subject. Avoid conventional wisdom unless you can qualify it or introduce a fresh perspective on it. Possible examples...*

Although an important part of one’s college education is learning to better understand others’ points of view, a persistent danger is that the students will simply be required to substitute the teacher’s answers for the ones they grew up uncritically believing.

WEAK THESIS TYPE 4: THE THESIS OFFERS PERSONAL CONVICTION AS THE BASIS FOR THE CLAIM. Problem Examples:

The songs of the punk rock group Minor Threat relate to the feelings of individuals who dare to be different. Their songs are just composed of pure emotion. Pure emotion is very important in music, because it serves as a vehicle to convey the important message of individuality. Minor Threat’s songs are meaningful to me because I can identify with them.

Sir Thomas More’s *Utopia* treats individualism as a serious but remediable social problem. His radical treatment of what we might now call “socialization” attempts to redefine the meaning and origin of individual identity.

Like conventional wisdom, personal likes and dislikes can lead inexperienced writers into knee-jerk reactions of approval or disapproval, often expressed in a moralistic tone. The writers of the problem examples above assume that their primary job is to judge their subjects or testify to their worth, not to evaluate them analytically

Solution: Try on other points of view honestly and dispassionately; treat your ideas as hypotheses to be tested rather than obvious truths. Possible examples...

Sir Thomas More's *Utopia* proposes an unworkable set of solutions to society's problems because, like communist Russia, it suppresses individualism.

WEAK THESIS TYPE 5: THE THESIS MAKES AN OVERLY BROAD CLAIM. PROBLEM EXAMPLES...

Violent revolutions have had both positive and negative results for man.

Othello is a play about love and jealousy.

Overly generalized theses avoid complexity. At their worst, as in the examples above, they settle for assertions broad enough to fit almost any subject and thus say nothing in particular about the subject at hand.

Solution: Convert broad categories and generic claims to more specific assertions; find ways to bring out the complexity of your subject. Possible examples...

Although violent revolutions begin to redress long-standing social inequities, they often do so at the cost of long-term economic dysfunction and the suffering that attends it.

Although *Othello* appears to attack jealousy, it also supports the skepticism of the jealous characters over the naïveté of the lovers.
